

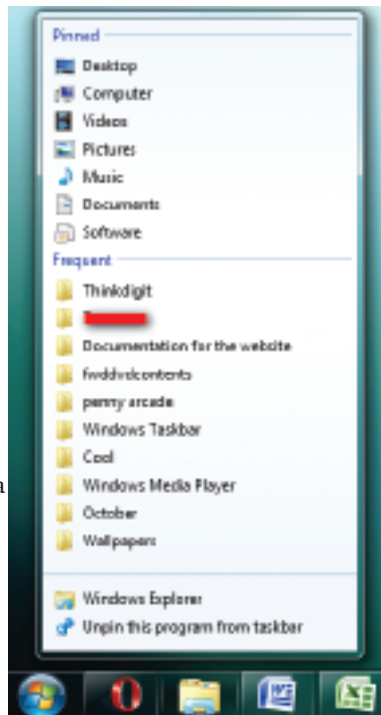
The Taskbar

Ever since Windows 95 introduced the taskbar and the Start button, this central aspect to the Windows interface hasn't seen any substantial changes. Windows Vista, of course, replaced the rectangular "Start" area with just a spherical logo, and did little else. Windows 7 Beta takes the taskbar to an all-new level, and it does so by intelligently extending the current functionality, not by introducing drastic changes. The taskbar is now thicker, almost twice the height of the older one. It also does away with the labels for programs launched (although this behavior can be changed). Finally, it introduces several key changes to how programs on the taskbar now work:

Managing open Windows using the taskbar



1. When a program is launched, its icon appears on the taskbar. The default behavior is without labels. When you hover over an icon, Windows 7 pops-up a small snapshot of the app (called a *preview*), moving the mouse over this snapshot will show a preview of that application Window. Move the mouse away, and the OS brings you back to your currently active application. This is a great way to quickly *peek* into other windows, without leaving the current application.
2. Multiple windows of a launched program (even tabs for some supported apps) are now grouped together under the same icon in (1) above. This is similar to the grouping done by XP and Vista, but is a much more elegant solution based on how the group's elements are exposed on mouse-hover over a launched program's icon. It shows a row



Windows Explorer recent items and libraries

of translucent windows, each representing either a new document or a new tab. So let's say you have four Word files open — this feature will show you a preview of the four and let you navigate to each tab or window using the mouse. You can also minimise, maximise and close a window using just this preview, removing the need to [Alt]+[Tab] to it.

3. Any program can be pinned to the taskbar. This is similar to the Quick Launch feature of past versions — but much more useful since a pinned program can not only launch a program, but also manage windows inside that launched program. Think of pinning as evolving the taskbar to a more dock-like behaviour of OS X (or the sundry-free dock applications available for Windows).
4. The pinning behaviour, when applied to Windows Explorer, exposes another cool feature — it lists your libraries. Why this is welcome will become apparent when we talk about libraries later.
5. Right-clicking on a pinned program pops up a list of recently open / created documents under that program — called a Jump List. This is a truly great feature as you can now open frequently used documents right from the taskbar, instead of hunting for them under Explorer or looking for them under a program's menu bar. Furthermore, each recent item in Jump List can be pinned, so you can quickly access important files by pinning them down, even if it's been a while since you have opened them.
6. In some programs such as Windows Media Player, you also see control overlays. You can thus play / pause, rewind / forward music without leaving your current application.
7. Other small changes include a thin vertical bar on the extreme right of the task bar. When you hover over this bar, Windows lets you peek at your Desktop. Moving away from the bar brings you back to your current application. This is a quick method of looking at gadgets that are now shown on the desktop. The thicker taskbar also allows for both date and time to be shown, about time too...

Personally, the ability to pin a program along with the History pop-up has completely changed the way we use the Start Menu — in as much as we rarely hit the Start button anymore.

Windows management

Some minor, but welcome changes to working with open programs: (1) You can drag open windows to the upper screen edge to maximise it. Dragging it back to the centre of the screen will restore the window (2) You can also drag a window to the left of your screen to make it fill the left half of your desktop. Ditto for the right